
COMPETITIVE DECISION BRIEF

telli

When a live competitor benchmark ages on two different clocks

Prepared by Evidence Axis

Checked: 2 Sep 2026 | Scope: public evidence only

GIFT #14

Executive readout

telli's live ElevenLabs comparison contains two different kinds of drift.

1

OUTBOUND BOUNDARY

The live page tells buyers not to choose ElevenLabs for outbound sales. ElevenLabs had shipped self-serve Batch Calling by May 2025, and by September said customers were qualifying leads and running outbound calling at scale - before telli's January 2026 evidence cutoff.

2

BUILDER BOUNDARY

The developer-focused framing aged differently. In September 2025 ElevenLabs still called its visual workflow builder "coming soon". By February 2026 it had a no-code interface for non-technical teams, and its current sales product advertises drag-and-drop no-code call flows.

3

WHY THIS MATTERS

This is not simply a stale page. One claim appears to have been too broad at the original cutoff; another became stale later. That creates a stronger reason to re-audit the whole eight-provider comparison layer.

Finding 01 - The outbound boundary was already too broad

The live "do not choose" rule conflicts with pre-cutoff product evidence.

TELLI LIVE PAGE

Workflow Automation: 2.0/5. The narrative says ElevenLabs has limited batch support and "no built-in automation or campaign management." The decision guide says: do not choose ElevenLabs if you need full call automation or run outbound sales.

28 MAY 2025

ElevenLabs launches Batch Calling for Conversational AI: CSV/XLS recipient upload, dynamic variables, scheduling, real-time monitoring, reporting, and API access for outbound campaigns.

03 SEP 2025

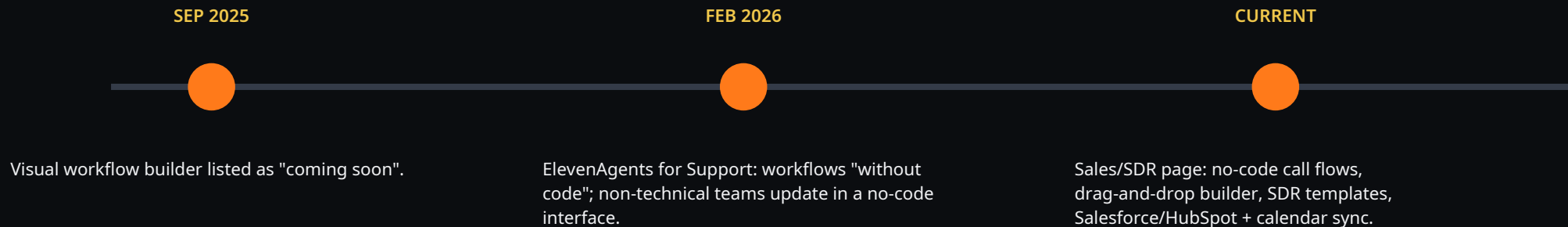
ElevenLabs describes Agents as a complete platform; says customers already use it to qualify leads and run outbound calling at scale. Its visual workflow builder is still listed as coming soon.

Decision read:

The evidence does not establish parity with telli. It establishes a narrower point: the blanket "not for outbound sales / no campaign management" boundary was already difficult to defend before the stated January 2026 snapshot.

Finding 02 - The builder boundary aged on a different clock

The developer-focused claim was more defensible earlier, then weakened after the snapshot.



Guardrail:

Do not claim the January 2026 builder score was definitively wrong. The public evidence only shows the visual builder was still forthcoming in September 2025, then no-code capability became explicit after the snapshot and is explicit today.

Strategic context - A technology layer moved upward

The supplier/platform boundary changed before it became a direct comparison problem.

APR 2025 - HISTORICAL USE

telli CEO Finn zur Muehlen told TechCrunch that voices used by telli were cloned using ElevenLabs or Cartesia. This establishes historical technology-layer use, not a current supplier relationship.

FEB 2026 - CAPITAL + SCOPE

ElevenLabs raised \$500M at an \$11B valuation and said it was doubling down on ElevenAgents for customer experience, sales and marketing, and internal workflows.

SEP 2026 - SALES PROOF

ElevenLabs reports its internal AI SDR Dom handled \$1M+ in qualified pipeline in one month at 92% qualification accuracy and saved 180 SDR hours. Dom is inbound today; outbound sequences are described as a next step.

Strategic read:

A company that telli publicly described as part of its voice-cloning layer in 2025 has expanded into the operational agent layer telli now compares against. Current telli use of ElevenLabs is NOT ESTABLISHED.

Decision implications

Three questions worth testing before treating the January benchmark as a current sales asset.

01 CLAIM ARCHITECTURE

Which competitive claims are durable enough to anchor a public battlecard, and which are short-shelf-life feature claims that need a refresh cadence?

02 EIGHT-PROVIDER RE-AUDIT

Does the same drift appear across Vapi, Regal AI, Synthflow, Retell, Fonio, Parloa and Bland - or is ElevenLabs an isolated case?

03 BUYER-SAFE WORDING

Where should telli replace absolute exclusions such as "do not choose" with narrower evidence-backed distinctions that remain defensible as adjacent platforms expand?

Evidence and method pointer

This brief uses public evidence only. The appendix separates fact, inference and not-established claims.

- Primary sources were used for telli and ElevenLabs product-state claims wherever available.
- The outbound finding uses a dated product release (Batch Calling, May 2025) plus a dated platform statement (Sep 2025), not only current marketing copy.
- The builder finding is intentionally split from outbound: the visual workflow builder was still forthcoming in Sep 2025, while no-code capability became explicit after telli's January 2026 snapshot.
- Historical telli use of ElevenLabs is supported by a direct CEO attribution in TechCrunch. Current use is not established.
- Dom is used only as fresh inbound production proof. It is not presented as proof of current outbound production performance.
- Appendix includes source register, claim map, timeline, wording guardrails, dropped claims and QA notes.

Paid decision frontier: Which public competitive claims should telli defend, narrow, retire or rebuild when the eight-provider benchmark is tested against current product reality and live sales objections?